hacked that. We came to understand that system. Now part of that computer system is ours. We have taken it back for general ownership.'

None of us ever harmed anybody or caused any damage in our night-time forays, but we were never naive enough to think that the authorities would see it that way. By about 1988, the Australian authorities were trying to establish some test cases to justify a new Computer Crimes Bill, and it was clear I had to be careful. I used to hide my floppy disks inside the beehive. I was sure the guys from the Bureau of Criminal Intelligence wouldn't risk getting stung for real as they went about their sting.

There were some totally inspired hackers who were friends of mine: Phoenix, Trax and Prime Suspect. The latter two bonded together with me into a group we called the International Subversives. We were doing nightly raids on the Canadian telecom company, Nortel, on NASA and on the Pentagon. One time, I got the passwords I needed to access the Overseas Telecoms Commission by phoning their office in Perth pretending to be a colleague. As I spoke, I played around me a tape I had made of fake office noise – photocopiers whirring, keyboards clicking, a hum of conversation – just to create the right ambience for my fraud. They came up with the password in seconds. It sounds playful, and in a way it was, I suppose. But when the new legislation came in we went from feeling like climbers breaking into a nature reserve to explore, to criminals facing ten years in jail. Some of my friends had already been busted, and I knew it was only a matter of time before I got raided.

In the event, my brother let them in. He was only eleven. By sheer good fortune I wasn't there. Anyway, the police had no evidence and the whole raid was a fishing expedition. There was a lot of fiction doing the rounds about hackers stealing from Citibank. Bullshit, actually. We were worried about stealing electricity to run our computers, and stealing phone calls and postage, but money, no. Far from looking for commercial gain, we were careful not to destroy anything in our path. If we hacked a system then we repaired our way back out of it, leaving, oftentimes, a back door to let ourselves back in again.

They started tapping some of our phones on a 24-hour basis. It was weird, and the weirdness crept into the characters of some of those kids. True to say, some of us were weird anyway, coming from what are now called dysfunctional families, where addictions had played a part, where disguises were already part of the picture. That was true enough of me, and